

EUOPLOCEPHALUS

Euoplocephalus belonged to a family of dinosaurs called the ankylosaurids, which were characterized by an armoured head and bony plating on the body. This dinosaur grew to about 6 m (20 ft) in length and weighed around two tonnes. Its tail, body, and neck were covered by plates and bands of tough, leathery skin set with bony studs. Two rows of larger spikes ran along its back. Even its eyes were protected by bony eyelids. Fused bony knobs on the end of the long tail formed a tail club, which the dinosaur could swing at attacking predators. *Euoplocephalus* was a herbivore – its beaked mouth was ideally suited for grazing on vegetation in the thick forests of the Late Cretaceous. It may even have used the blunt hoofs at the end of each toe to dig in the ground for roots and tubers. *Euoplocephalus* was probably a solitary dinosaur, though juveniles may have lived in herds.



SIZE 6 m (20 ft)
DATE Late Cretaceous
DISTRIBUTION N. America
GROUP Ankylosaurids

ARMoured HEAD >

The head had a massive skull, with protective spikes at the back and a beaked mouth. The name *Euoplocephalus* means “well armoured head”.

✓ NECK VERTEBRAE

Although the head was relatively small and the neck short, the neck vertebrae had to be strong to support the head's weighty, studded armour plating.



short shoulder blade

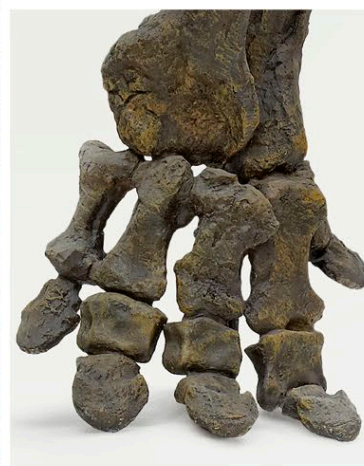
WALKING TANK >

Euoplocephalus had a wide, low-slung body, supported by short, stout limbs. In cross-section it would have been almost round. Its small head was protected at the back by spikes, and its beaked mouth would have had small, ribbed teeth adapted for munching plants.

< STUDED PLATES

One of the most important features of *Euoplocephalus* was its armour plating. This was made of tough plates of skin studded with ridged ovals of bone.

broad, rounded ribcage



^ FRONT FOOT

This dinosaur's limbs were short, stocky, and strong. The front feet had short, sturdy toes, which helped to support the considerable body weight.



^ TAIL VERTEBRAE

About halfway along the tail, the typical tail vertebrae – armed with spikes – gave way to a fused, bony structure. This rigid structure would have supported the club at the end of the tail. The tail would have been quite muscular.



^ TAIL CLUB

The massive tail club was made of fused bones – two large and several smaller bones. This weapon was probably used in defence.

in life, bony studs were covered with scaly horn

elbow joint